

El Paso School Has Built Top Athletic Program

UTEP Can Hold Own In WAC Play

EDITOR'S NOTE: This is the first in a two-part series describing the two new additions to the Western Athletic Conference. Today's article gives a picture of the University of Texas at El Paso.

By ABE CHANIN
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Eddie Mullens, the king of cliches, puts it this way: "Before George McCarty became athletic director at the University of Texas at El Paso the athletic program was so poor even the turkey buzzards wanted no part of it."

Mullens, the most colorful sports information director in the Rocky Mountain area, is happier than a bear caught in a honeycomb today because UTEP is one of two schools invited to join the Western Athletic Conference. The other school is Colorado State University.

Located not far from the Mexican border, the school is located in a heavy population belt. There are 372,000 living in El Paso County with larger



BOBBY DOBBS

... UTEP's successful grid coach

population across the border in Juarez.

It was the Texas College of Mines that first started playing football in 1914 and after World War II the school changed its name to Texas Western Col-

lege. A part of the University of Texas, the El Paso school only last year won university status. It officially now is the University of Texas at El Paso and its colors are orange and white, resembling UT at Austin. And from the days of Texas College of Mines the teams still carry the nickname of 'Miners.'

The school was a member of the old Border Conference along with the Arizona and New Mexico schools so there are old rivalries in existence. Ever since the Border Conference broke up the El Paso school has remained without a conference.

"And that's not good," says George McCarty, the former New Mexico State basketball coach and athletic director who moved south in 1953 to El Paso. "You need to belong to some conference—that's a foregone conclusion. And we've been preparing to be in this conference. In fact, we've operated under WAC rules since February 1966.

"I'll tell you this about the WAC. It's going to be one of the finest in the country now that it is up to a full-size conference of eight teams."

This is the way McCarty, UTEP athletic director, describes his athletic program:

"Our football is very stable now that Bobby Dobbs is in his third year as our head coach. We will be competitive with WAC teams. We now have 106 scholarships for football, including freshmen. Our attendance for football has climbed to a record average of 26,862 and last year we paid Wyoming over \$28,000 for playing in El Paso.

"Our basketball program will put us in very good position in the WAC. We won the NCAA national championship two seasons back and with us and Colorado State I think this will be the toughest basketball league in the country. We have 20 basketball scholarships and for this next season we are moving into the Coliseum which will



GEORGE MCCARTY

... rebuilt UTEP

athletic program

seat 8,414. Last year we sold out our own 5,000-seat gym even before the season started.

"In track and field we'll have our best team next spring. We won't be champions, but we'll

have a very good squad. As far as baseball we had the school's best record in history—I believe 32-14—last season. Tennis and golf, although we put five scholarships into each sport, still are proving difficult. "We still don't have swimming or competitive wrestling or gymnastics, but we are making plans."

UTEP expects an enrollment of 8,500 this fall. On the school's athletic staff are Dobbs, the former Army star at West Point, as head football coach; Don Haskins, who took UTEP to the NCAA basketball championship; Andy Cohen, former major leaguer, baseball coach; Wayne Vandenburg, track coach; Leslie Berkes, tennis; Luke Thompson, golf and Ross Moore, trainer.

Last year's football record was 6-4 and in basketball the Miners were 22-6 and one of the nation's top-ranked quintets.

UTEP is scheduled to play both Arizona and Arizona State in football this season. The Miners come to Tucson Oct. 14.